To weed out dissent, Honecker requested the State Secretariat for University Activities oust 183 students from academies and universities, accusing them of expressing opposition to the policy of the Government by both words and actions.

At a thrilling Politburo meeting on 8 July, Ulbricht's unpopularity became evident when every member – except Hermann Matern, chairman of the Party Control Commission and Honecker – demanded he step down. However, there was no question of the Soviets risking further instability by helping unseat Ulbricht – the Kremlin stuck with the tried and true.

Amid this upheaval, Beria had been eliminated in the first post-Stalin purge in Moscow, leaving his supporters in the SED Politburo, Wilhelm Zaisser and Rudolf Herrnstadt, at the mercy of Ulbricht who declared them 'enemies of the German people' and replaced them with uncritical supporters. Honecker later recounted that Beria wanted to liquidate the GDR as a socialist state and give up the goal of a comprehensive construction of socialism. 'Just at this time, in 1953, Herrnstadt tried with Zaisser to topple Walter Ulbricht, at a point in time when the Party required firm leadership. After the arrest of Beria, this plan collapsed.'14 (In fact, Beria wanted to ditch East German communism entirely, and seek the reunification of a neutral Germany in return for generous Western compensation).

As the atmosphere calmed, Ulbricht was feted in Moscow during August when the Soviets promised more economic aid, an end to reparations payments, and elevated the diplomatic missions between the two governments to embassies. Damage-limitation to heal the wounds of 17 June saw some citizens granted travel concessions and, for a brief moment, the tense relationship between church and state became friendlier when seventy church officials were released from detention and Grotewohl promised more tolerance to the Christian community. Even Honecker, who had been staging a campaign against Evangelical youth groups, graciously received a delegation of leading church representatives and heard them out sympathetically. He expressed no objections to involving young people in church community work and promised that all young people who had lost their apprenticeships for belonging to Christian youth groups would be